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Chicago Tribune



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SUNDAY, APRIL 6, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



U. of I. shrugs off rules on athletes’ NIL deals

Records offer rare look at lack of accountability in big-money world of college sports

By Stacy St. Clair | Chicago Tribune and Jodi S. Cohen | ProPublica
Data analysis by Joe Mahr | Chicago Tribune Photography by John J. Kim | Chicago Tribune

Amid a standout season last year, University of Illinois men’s basketball stars found themselves in high demand as they reached the Elite Eight in the 2024 NCAA Tournament.

Three players appeared in a commercial for a local BMW dealership.

One did an Instagram post for TurboTax.

Another promoted an apartment complex near the Urbana-Champaign campus.

But not one of those endorsements — which are allowed now that student-athletes can profit from their personal brands — was reported to the university, as state law requires.

In fact, the entire Illini team reported just \$9,100 in name, image and likeness deals during the 2023-24 season, according to records obtained by the Tribune and ProPublica. By comparison, the average earnings reported for a male basketball player in the Big Ten and the three other biggest college conferences were more than \$145,000 during that school year, according to data that insti-

tutions voluntarily provided to the NCAA.

The Illini basketball team’s missing disclosures reflect an indifference to documenting NIL deals across the athletic department, the news organizations found. Athletes from 20 sports combined have reported earning only about \$1.2 million in three-plus years, compared with the \$20 million Ohio State

\$9.1K

Total earnings reported by Illini men’s basketball team in 2023-24

\$145K

Average earnings for a Power Four male basketball player that year

Above: Ben Quattrone, left, who has made deals with University of Illinois athletes to promote his chain of car dealerships, greets Treanette Redding and her son Terrence Shannon Jr., a former Illinois basketball star, at a home game in February.

University’s football team reportedly received in a single year, or a University of Missouri quarterback who alone is estimated to have made more than \$1 million in NIL deals.

By shrugging its shoulders at Illinois’ reporting requirements, the university is failing to compile a complete picture of how its students — some of them still teenagers — are navigating a relatively new terrain rife with legal, moral and financial pitfalls.

“I find that maddening and irresponsible,” said Bill Carter, founder of Student-Athlete Insights, which provides NIL consulting services. “It seems unethical to me to allow 18-to-23-year-olds to participate in something life-altering like this but provide no structure, no support, no direction.”

Officials from the Department of Intercollegiate Athletics say they inform the school’s athletes

Turn to NIL, Page 8

Solution sought for ‘teen takeovers’

Residents worry about safety, others call for investment in youth

By Rebecca Johnson, Nell Salzman and Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

When Khalil Cotton was growing up on Grand Boulevard on the city’s South Side, he and his friends often struggled to find places to hang out outside of school. A hoop with a crate on a pole was a replacement for a basketball court because there wasn’t one nearby, he said.

Cotton, now 21, started to attend “trend gatherings” — large meet-ups of young people downtown — when he was in middle school, simply for a place to go.

“You want to feel like you belong,” he said. “Gathering sometimes makes kids feel like they’re all together and all having fun. Like this is where we should be.”

Hundreds of young adults like Cotton have attended what are now commonly called “teen takeovers” over the past few years in the city’s downtown neighborhoods. Videos of these gatherings — including two notable ones just last month, which ended with a 15-year-old boy sustaining a graze wound and a tourist being shot as she walked back to a hotel with her son — have circulated across social media, generating debate in the City Council and neighborhood groups alike as summer approaches.

Streeterville residents say they’re worried about safety and

Turn to Teens, Page 6

INSIDE

Trump goes all in on his broad tariff bet

Supporters are hopeful for now despite markets’ worst week since the onset of COVID-19. Democrats see an opening. **Nation & World**

‘You have to look at the glass as half-full’

It might be a bumpy season, but Cubs fans should just relax and enjoy the ride. **Paul Sullivan in Chicago Sports**

The \$265 million tech bill

Plan to streamline Cook County, state computer systems led to high costs, delays

By David Jackson, A.D. Quig and Kristen Axtman

This story is a collaboration between Injustice Watch and the Chicago Tribune.

In a flurry of contracts inked a decade ago, some of Illinois’ most powerful political figures declared it was time to fix their obsolete and expensive computer systems.

Cook County Board President Toni Preckwinkle called for an online method to deliver error-free property records and tax bills.

Then-Clerk of the county

Circuit Court Dorothy Brown wanted seamless technology so everyone could read and file cases on their laptops.

And the Illinois Supreme Court sought a single unified dashboard linking the appellate courts with all 102 county courthouses from Cairo to Galena.

In a three-year window starting in 2015, executives of a little-known Plano, Texas, corporation — Tyler Technologies Inc. — persuaded all three to give them the crucial job.

The collective price tag was initially \$75 million and what offi-

cials called the “go-live” deadlines were three to five years out.

But since then, an Injustice Watch and Chicago Tribune investigation found, the cumulative projected cost swelled to more than \$250 million while execution was dogged by slowdowns and shortcomings. Two of the projects have yet to reach their declared finish line, and the third is still in need of fixes.

The Cook County property records project, which started in 2015 and was supposed to be

Turn to Systems, Page 4



Tyler Technologies was hired to help the Cook County Circuit Court digitize records and create a new case management system accessible through terminals such as these at the Daley Center. **BRIAN CASSELLA/TRIBUNE**

TODAY’S WEATHER



High 50 Low 37

Complete forecast on Opinion, Page 12

\$5.75 city and suburbs and elsewhere
177th year No. 96 © Chicago Tribune

